CHARRED RAINBOW TROUT WITH GRILLED RAMPS, CATTAILS, AND CARROT-HONEY PUREE

serves 2 to 4

Chef Shane Chartrand of the maskêkosak (Enoch Cree Nation) grew up in central Alberta with two adopted parents—his father, of the Métis Nation, and his mother, a member of the Mi'kmaq Nation and of Irish-Canadian descent. When he was a kid, his family ate the birds they raised, the moose meat his dad hunted, and trout, like this, that they fished together.

Like me, he worked his way up through restaurants that had nothing to do with his Indigenous heritage. Over time, however, he started looking to his roots and overall Indigenous history for inspiration to start cooking what he called progressive Indigenous cuisine.

To read more about his story and try his recipes, check out his book, *Tawâw*. I'm thrilled he shared this recipe for a crispy-skinned trout served over a luscious honeyed carrot puree and simply cooked seasonal vegetables. It's a taste of the Northern Forests in spring. As always, when handling nettles, wear gloves until after they are cooked. Otherwise, the leaves and stems can sting.

- 2 cups vegetable broth
- 4 large carrots, peeled or scrubbed well and cut crosswise into ½-inch-thick rounds
- 2 tablespoons honey
- Fine sea salt
- 4 ounces nettles
- 4 thin cattail shoots (see About Cattails, page 374)
- 4 ramps, young spring onions, or scallions
- 3 tablespoons sunflower oil
- 2 skin-on trout fillets (about 8 ounces each), halved crosswise to serve 4
- 1 teaspoon cider vinegar
- Flaky sea salt, for sprinkling

In a deep saucepan, bring the broth to a boil over high heat. Reduce the heat to medium, add the carrots, cover, and cook for 10 to 12 minutes, until very tender. Turn off the heat.

Using a slotted spoon, transfer the carrots to a blender (reserve the broth). Let cool until warm. Start pureeing the carrots while slowly adding some of the broth from the saucepan, blending just until you have a nice, smooth puree. Add the honey and season with fine sea salt. Pour the puree into a clean medium saucepan and keep warm.

Set up a large bowl of ice and water and place near the stove. Pour the broth remaining in the deep saucepan into a container and save for another use. Rinse out the saucepan, fill with salted water, and bring to a boil.

While wearing gloves, pull the nettle leaves from the stems. Using tongs, add the leaves to the boiling water and cook for 10 seconds, then transfer to the ice bath. Drain and squeeze the nettles dry.

Discard the outer layers of the cattails until you reach their tender inner cores. (See About Cattails, page 374, for more instructions.) Rinse them well.

Preheat an outdoor grill to medium-high or a cast-iron skillet or grill pan over medium-high heat.

In a bowl, toss together the cattails, ramps, and 1 tablespoon of the oil and season with fine sea salt. Add to the grill grates or skillet and sear for about 2 minutes, turning frequently, until charred on both sides. Set aside.

(recipe continues)

If you're using a grill, heat a cast-iron skillet on the grates. Otherwise, continue using your skillet or grill pan on the stove over medium-high heat. Add 1 tablespoon of the oil. When it's just starting to shimmer, season both sides of the fresh trout with fine sea salt.

Add the fish skin-side down to the skillet and cook for about 3 minutes, or until the skin is crisp and well charred. If, after the skin is charred, the flesh is warm all the way throughout, you won't need to flip it. But if it's still cool in the center or if you prefer more well-done fish, flip the fillets and cook until opaque throughout.

Spoon the warm carrot puree onto plates. Add the grilled ramps and then arrange the fish on top. Top with the cattails.

Gently toss the nettles with the vinegar and the remaining 1 tablespoon of oil. Divide the nettles among the plates. Season everything with flaky sea salt and serve.

ABOUT CATTAILS

If you live anywhere near fresh water, you've probably seen seven-foot-tall cattails (*Typha latifolia* and *Typha angustifolia*) growing with their signature brown fluffy seed heads. They grow widely all over Turtle Island in and alongside ponds, streams, marshes, and swamps. Many parts of the plant are edible, including the roots, pollen, and (my favorite part) the tender, crisp shoots. You can also use the dried leaves for weaving.

In spring, after the new cattails push through the mud but before their flowers form, their inner stems are wonderfully crisp-tender with a flavor reminiscent of cucumber. If you go out to harvest them, practice good foraging tactics, as always. Look for cattails growing in or near water that's free from extensive human traffic and various forms of pollution, including runoff from pesticide-treated fields. Also, make sure you're definitely harvesting cattail shoots, which might look like other shoots in the spring. (If you're not sure, ask an expert.)

To harvest the shoots, you want to try to pull off the bottom part of the plant as close to the ground as possible without disturbing the roots. To do so, push back any outer papery leaves if you can and grip the tender inner core where the plant meets the ground. Give it a twist and it should detach from the plant.

Or you can simply cut the plant at its base with sharp scissors.

After you clean the cattail shoots well, you can eat them raw. Some people find raw cattails give them a fuzzy feeling in their throat, so before you make the salad on page 370, taste a bite to see how you feel. If you get that fuzzy feeling, then give them a quick sauté, which will deactivate the compound that causes that reaction.